

and boyfriends tend to be hurt about three canceled dates in a row and are unlikely to believe an explanation of “because monsters” even if it is utterly sincere.

Theme

A theme is a recurring idea that shows up during the chronicle, usually best expressed in a short phrase such as “love is precious” or “power corrupts.” Although some themes are morals, this is not a requirement — a theme can be explored from multiple angles with no clear “correct” interpretation, presented as a matter to be pondered more than a question to be answered.

When designing a chronicle, choosing a central theme helps determine the sort of stories that will be told — “power corrupts” naturally lends itself to a lot of intrigue and politicking, for instance, while “vengeance solves everything” suggests very violent, aggressive stories.

Themes are also useful because they help a Storyteller stay centered as a story or chronicle unfolds, giving her a central idea she can return to when she’s not sure what to do next or what direction to take an unexpected turn of events. If the theme of the chronicle is “power corrupts” and the characters unexpectedly take down the intended villain early, for example, the Storyteller can use the theme as inspiration to start a new story about how an ally winds up becoming puffed up on this success and turns out even worse than the original antagonist.

While they are useful storytelling tools, it’s best to handle themes with a light touch whenever possible; feeling like you’re being hit over the head with a “moral” can rob it of a lot of its power. Fortunately, this can be avoided by incorporating the theme in small ways as well as large ones — in a game with “power corrupts” as a theme, for instance, the Storyteller could include a developing news story about a local politician embroiled in a corruption scandal in the background of the chronicle. This doesn’t necessarily impact play directly, but helps underscore the theme in a subtle but persistent way.

Mood

If a theme is an idea or message that comes up repeatedly during game, a mood is a persistent feeling, an emotional filter that colors the environment and actions of the chronicle. A story with a “simmering tension” mood finds the characters constantly encountering situations where serious problems and strong feelings lurk below apparently calm surfaces, while a story with “bittersweet hope” is likely to include some conflicted resolutions and difficult sacrifices.

It’s important to understand that setting a mood for a story — or a chronicle — doesn’t mean that every character the players meet must express that emotion. Indeed, moments of contrast are necessary in order to underscore the importance of the overall mood, as well as avoid a sense of emotional monotony. Even in a “simmering tension” game there should be moments of release, otherwise the tension becomes ordinary and loses its sting.



Crossing the Threshold



One very useful discussion to have before a story begins is what thresholds different players have when it comes to what they enjoy seeing in games. For example, some players don’t mind a bit of a gore and other visceral horror, while others might be put off by it. Likewise, a player may not want to see issues like domestic violence or sexual assault come up in game. It’s a lot better to find this out earlier than later! Some players don’t mind pushing the edge a bit, but others prefer to keep things lighter, and sorting out who’s who and where the limits are is a good way to avoid messy misunderstandings later on.

It’s important to remember that the purpose of thresholds is not to “sanitize” games, but rather to make sure that everyone around the table is comfortable and enjoying themselves. Or rather if they’re uncomfortable, it’s a good kind of uncomfortable — like the shocks of a horror film or the nail biting that accompanies a thrilling tale — rather than a more personally upsetting sort of discomfort. It can be a fine distinction at times, but it’s still an important one.



Bringing up mood in play is a matter of making sure the associated feelings and emotions are never far from the surface — think of it as the “default state” of the chronicle, from an emotional standpoint. While events may temporarily move away from it, in the end the mood is the emotional tone that the chronicle returns to naturally.

Antagonists

Every story needs some opposition to the characters; otherwise they’d simply get what they need with no fuss at all, and where’s the fun in that? A memorable antagonist can be the backbone of an entire story or even an entire chronicle, so it’s important to take some time and design them right. And when making really great opposition, it’s a good idea to go beyond the character sheets and dice pools and get into their heads a bit to understand why they’re against the characters in the first place.

To begin with, all antagonists should have clear goals — even if the characters don’t see them right away — and reasonable plans to achieve those goals. (Well, reasonable to the antagonist anyway, if not necessarily to anyone else.) Whether their methods involve brute force, sneaky manipulation, magical power, or some other ploy depends on the antagonist in question, but their plans should always play to their strengths. They want to succeed, after all, and just like the characters that means they should employ their best assets to make that happen.

Of course, it’s also good to design weaknesses in antagonists and their plans, ones that clever players can uncover and exploit. This can be anything from an actual physical allergy or vulnerability to a dark secret or personality flaw that allows the

